In intelligence, Meki belonged to the school of HUMINT, human intelligence. HUMINT is the aircraft carrier of the art of intelligence. The centrality and stature of HUMINT began with the story of the biblical spies and will always retain its importance. HUMINT is a one-on-one contest between the hunter and his prey. The hunter, in order to succeed, must be endowed with an almost impossible combination of traits; he must understand the cultural environment of his prey; knowledge of his language is a great advantage; he must pick apart information about his prey, separating the wheat from the chaff; he must observe him, learn his personality, his qualities, his weaknesses; he must choose the best way to approach him and establish contact with him; he must develop a personal bond with him, create a dependence, and corrupt him. Finally, he must lead his prey to betray his people, his country, and his family, without damaging his dependence on the hunter. Meki, throughout his entire intelligence career, lived and breathed HUMINT and contributed immensely to this profession in which Israeli intelligence has excelled.

Today we have come full circle. We have developed SIGINT, COMINT, ELINT, and VISINT. We have invested billions in all these, and today we find ourselves in a hopeless situation. The “Queen of Battle” of the intelligence profession, which is also the cheapest, really no money in comparison with the other disciplines, has closed shop. Saddam Hussein was captured only because of HUMINT. Bin Laden has not been found yet because of a lack of HUMINT. All types of technical intelligence failed to provide an accurate intelligence picture of Saddam Hussein’s nonconventional capabilities. One top source—if only there were one—would do for free what billions of dollars’ worth of technology could not do.

In my memory, Meki was one of the few who cautioned about the deterioration of HUMINT. “Bikta,” the Tzomet division’s branch in Iran, was a HUMINT factory during the time that Meki was its director. This branch’s consumption of “Minox” film was greater than that of the entire intelligence community put together. The branch’s main intelligence products were not field reports from a source about something he heard from a second source, who had heard it from a third source. The main intelligence products were hundreds of thousands of pages photographed by —yes—agents. The IDF’s successful operational responses to the Arab armies during the Six-Day War and the Yom Kippur War were made